STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 14 · How That Looks on a Man

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey. Good to see you. Uh, some of you came in talking. Some of you came in hoping the talking could wait a minute. Both of you sat down. That's the hard part. Glad you kept the chair. If you're new with us, I'm Wes. You can catch this from the seat you're in. Last lesson we said a word most men sand down. I sinned. Some of you got it out whole. Some of you— some of you trimmed it on the way out of your mouth. You still said more than you said the time before. Keep that. In this lesson the inside gets a shape. Sin puts clothes on a man, and the clothes can look like somebody you'd hand your keys to.

Competence is not righteousness.

The hidden place can still be eating. One sentence holds four marks of a real man. I won't, uh, pull them apart in this lesson. I want them in the air while we look at what sin wears. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

Sin on a man does not always show up as a wreck. Uh, sometimes it shows up as a man people are glad to see. And under that, something is aimed the wrong way. If you don't know the shapes, you'll look at that man in the morning and tell him he's alright. I have— I have told him that. With a straight face. You know, I believed me. The shapes have names. Yours is on the list. You may feel two of them. Pick the one that had the most hours. The one that, uh, carried your keys. If you claim every name so none of them can land, that's a very thorough dodge. One shape. The one with the hours. Don't hide in the list.

Proverbs fourteen, verse twelve. There is a way that appears to be right, but in the end it leads to death.

Appears. That's the word that does the work. A way can look sensible while you're standing in the middle of it. Uh, nobody picks a shape because he wants to rot. He picks it because it looks like sense. Like rest. Like being the strong one. Like keeping everybody steady. And the end of that road is not the picture he had when he stepped onto it. A man stays late and calls it providing. The talk at home is the thing he was late to avoid. The lateness, uh, looks like love. It appears right. You will not feel the rot on the day you choose the shape. You feel the usefulness. The dead end shows up later, in a house that learned to live around you. I mean, that's why good men get fooled. The shape comes dressed for the job he already respects. Write this, uh, where you'll see it. Competence is not righteousness.

A man can run the work in front of him with a steady hand and be dying in the place he will not open.

Open the drawer before somebody else has to. I'm gonna give you the names. Short, first. Then we'll stay with them. The drawer. A second story, kept out of sight. The fortress. Strength that will not be helped. The scoreboard. Ranking the room in your chest. The podium. A good man, while somebody's watching. The throne. Every talk in the house has to be won. Contempt. The throne, with the sound

turned down. The recliner. Rest that costs the house a man. Those are the ones I see. Uh, yours is in there. Hold your pick until we've looked them in the face.

The drawer first. This is the hidden set. The life people greet, and the other one. Sometimes it's only the true sentence you will not say out loud. A habit of hiding what you really think is already a drawer. It does not have to hold a scandal to be locked. The lock, uh, is the problem. When nothing is hidden, you stop spending your strength defending a door. I kept— I kept a little spiral pad in the console of my car. Every time my wife and I missed each other, I wrote her line down. Not mine. I told myself I was trying to understand. Uh, I was building a file. Months on, uh, I found it under a stack of gas receipts, and my own handwriting made me sick. I almost tossed it and called that the end of it. Tossing it without naming it is just a cleaner lock. She never knew, uh, about the pad. That was the point. And it was the whole problem.

The fortress is next. This is the man who brings the ladder and will not say his back hurts. You offer, uh, the other end. He says he's got it. He always says he's got it. People start believing him. He starts believing them. It looks like a man carrying weight. A responsible man can still be helped. This one can't, and he calls that mature. A man at my table asked what was heavy. I told him about a deadline. He waited. I told him, you know, about another one. He said, I didn't ask about the work. I laughed. Then I moved us over to his problem, which I was glad to hold. Mine stayed in my pocket. I went home proud of how little I needed. My house was not proud. They had a man who would fix a hinge and would not say he was tired.

The scoreboard. He walks into a room and, uh, he ranks it. Not with his mouth. In his chest. Who got the nod. Whose name people remember. He can't be glad when another man gets a win. And his own life never gives him a place to sit down. The score updates. It does not rest. It happens before you notice. I caught it in myself at a table like this one. A man told a small true thing about his boy, and the room got quiet in a good way. I felt it. Right under the feeling, I checked whether my story had landed the same. It had not. That's the scoreboard. It can run during a good moment and steal it, and nobody hears a word. Gladness is part of a free man. If another man's win makes you smaller, uh, the board is still running. God's pay does not rank you against another man. The podium. This one dresses up like righteousness. He is patient where the room can see it. He is generous where it will be noticed. Then he gets to a place where nobody is grading him, and the patience is gone. Uh, the gap between those two men is the performance. What you only do when eyes are on you, that's the podium. I wrote — I wrote a man in my group a careful note. Warm. I took my time, uh, so he'd feel respected. Then I walked into my own kitchen and got short with my wife about the same kind of wait. She had been waiting on me too. The note got a thank-you later. She got the short version. I called the note leadership. It was a show. With decent handwriting. The fourth mark is God's pay, not the room's. The podium already took its pay from people who don't really know him. That account closes. Don't live for it.

The throne. Every talk in the house has to be won. He wins it, uh, loud. Or he wins it by going quiet until the other person feels foolish. Or he wins it with a little cut that would pass for a joke if you weren't the one it landed on. He calls that, uh, leadership. Ask the people in that house. A lot of their care goes into not setting you off. I have won arguments that small. I didn't feel cruel. I felt correct. Correct was the costume. Uh, harsh still has your name on it when the volume stays low. If somebody

in your house gets careful when you come in, fear can wear good manners. Get off the seat. Get low, in front of the people who have had to read you before you say, uh, good morning.

Contempt is the throne with the sound turned down. A correction of her story at a birthday supper, one detail that didn't matter, said with a smile. A short laugh when a younger man admits he's scared. A look at the clock while your boy is still talking. You can thank God with your mouth and treat his image cheap with the same mouth. If both live there, the shape is already on you. The recliner. On most men it does not look lazy. It looks like a man who decided the hard part of the day is over, and the house can live on whatever he has left. He sits. The hours go. Know that chair, right? I have called it coming down off the day. The house called it a dad on the property and not in the room.

How many of you heard a name and your stomach already answered. Let me see a show of hands. Go on. Yeah. You can put them down. That drop was information. Don't argue with it yet.

I want to tell you about a man. I'll call him Boyd. Boyd kept the fields lined for a small school district. If a pipe broke, uh, on a Saturday, Boyd was who they called. He came. People handed him, uh, the keys, and then they stopped worrying. At home there was a wife, three kids, and a hall closet with the board games stacked on the floor. Behind the games, a yellow envelope. Short lines in pencil. Times she had sighed. Times a kid had pushed back. Times he had felt unseen. He told himself, uh, a steady man keeps the facts. The office thought, uh, he was a gift. His middle girl asked her mom if the family was in trouble. Dad went to the closet after supper, she said, and came out with his jaw set. Mom didn't know about the envelope. She asked him. He said it was work papers. She let it go. A little later — a little later he told me, standing by his cooler at the field. He hadn't planned a confession. The girl had asked him too, and he heard his own lie in a child's mouth.

I said, Boyd, that envelope is running your house. He got hot. Told me I didn't know what he carried. I said the pages were still his. He went quiet. Then he said the true thing. He was afraid. If he stopped writing it down, he'd have to admit he was harsh.

He took the envelope to the kitchen the next evening. He didn't read her the list. He said, this was me building a case. I'm sorry. She put her hand on the envelope, and she cried. He told me afterward what undid him. The fields were still lined. The mowers still ran. Nobody at the school had a word of complaint. He had been using a good job as proof he was a good man. Those are two different proofs.

Boyd could keep a whole place looking right while a yellow envelope was teaching his kids to watch his jaw.

That's the claim, in a house. Competence is not righteousness.

A clean report will lie to you as long as the work is still getting done. Sin lies to the man who's wearing it. So you need a test that does not come, uh, from your own mirror. The hiding test. What would shame you if a brother from this room stood beside you while it was opened. The thing you angle away when somebody walks up. If there is a place like that, the place is already speaking. You don't have to wait until the thing inside it gets worse. Uh, the lock is the confession you haven't made. The no test. When was the last time somebody told you no and you let the no stand. If you can't find the day, you may be sitting on a throne and calling it standards. The watch test. What do you do only when people are looking. The man in the credited hour, and the man in the hour with no credit on it.

Name the gap, uh, out loud. Don't dress it up. The fear test. Who in your house gets careful when you come through. If a name comes up, get off the seat the same day. In front of them. Before you build a speech. You don't have to run every test before you go home. One honest look beats a whole stack you only think about. And the one I want you to actually run. If you're married, ask her where she sees you hiding and where she sees you harsh. Pick an hour that isn't already a fight. If you ask her and then explain why she's reading it wrong, you ran a different test. The throne. Hear the whole answer. Then thank her.

I ran that ask. She was rinsing a cup at the sink. I said, where do you see me hiding, and where do I get harsh. She dried her hands. She said, you leave the room without leaving the house. And you get sharp when you're tired. I almost said, you don't know the day I had. That sentence was, uh, right there. My boy was in the next room. He didn't need my defense. He needed the thank you to be the last word. So I set that sentence down. I said, thank you for saying it straight. She looked at me like she was waiting for the but. There wasn't one. That was the win. Small. And it was real. Uh, the next day I told a brother the two sentences she actually used. He said he'd ask me when he heard the sharp one coming. The thank you is the courage. Your chest can be hot. Say it anyway. Uh, if you're single, same test, different person. Ask the brother, uh, who knows you when you are not performing. Or ask your mother, if she's the one who has watched. Whole answer. No defense loaded in your head while she talks, or while he talks. Then thank them. Thanking is you leading when your pride wants a rebuttal. I mean, the rebuttal can sound holy. It can sound like context. Context can come later, as honesty. If it comes first, it's the throne keeping the chair. Then tell a brother what's in the drawer. Even if the drawer is only that habit of hiding what you really think. Give him permission. Permission to say you are the man when he sees the shape on you. That is a brother refusing to call a lock a personality. You need him. And some man in here needs you to be him. Love him enough to be specific.

Now let me walk the room. The shape does not wait on your season. Young men. You can build a drawer in a bedroom that still has your childhood in the closet. You can rank your friends before you have a title. You can perform for a very small crowd and call it growing up. A young man can hide a whole opinion behind a joke and call the joke his personality. That's a drawer. It starts before anybody hands you a bill. Uh, start while the thing is light. It gets heavier the longer you feed it. Single men. Watch the drawer, and watch the podium. Your unwatched, uh, hours. And the payoff of looking solid around church people. Let a brother in while the hidden thing is still a habit, before it becomes another room you live in. Marriage is, uh, good. It is not the morning you become honest. Don't hand a future wife a lock you refused to open while you were free to open it. Married men. She already knows more than your speech does. Listen. The speech you build, uh, in your head while she talks is the throne trying to keep its seat. If the house is loud with little kids and you are empty, empty is, uh, real. Harsh still has your name on it. The people closest to you are often spent past what you can see. Say the sorry the same day. Don't save it for a better mood. The better mood is a story the throne tells. If the marriage ended, watch the quiet tally. Who tried. Who left. Who looks settled on a Sunday. That tally will offer you a job every morning. It feels like staying awake. It is a scoreboard. Put it down. The Father who sees what is done in secret is not grading you against her life.

If you came in hurt, hear this before anything else. The wound is real. I am not calling it something you invented. Naming the shape does not erase what was done to you. The wound— the wound does not get the pen for every hour from here on. You can be hurt and still be the one hiding. Both can sit in the same man. Be kind, uh, to the wound. Take the pen back. Older men, look hard at the fortress. A long road teaches some of us how to need nothing, and it can pass, uh, for wisdom. A man I'll call Reece. People sent the new guys to him. He showed up, uh, with soup. He changed tires in the dark. He never called anybody for his own trouble. When his knee went, he drove himself and told the table he was just stiff. Uh, a younger man followed him out and watched him take a long minute getting that leg into the car. Reece said, don't fuss. The younger man said, I'm here. Reece sat with the door open. Then he said, I forgot how to let a man stand next to me unless I was the one helping.

He'd helped half the men at that table. He could not name a need of his own. That's a fortress with years on it. The table had the helper. They did not have the man. If you are the one people send the new guy to, let one of them actually know you. Needing help is a man who can still be helped. And if the work is going well, the job can be praised and the drawer can be rotting in the same stretch of days. I have watched a good report make a man deaf to the person across the table at supper. I have been that man. The report was true. The man was still hiding. Don't let a strong run at work talk you out of an honest look.

I don't want you leaving with a list and no mercy. The shapes are a diagnosis. They are not the last word on you. First John one, verse nine. If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness.

Confess. The sentence can be, uh, short. I sinned. Then the specific thing. Then stop. Don't spend the next breath building a case for why it was reasonable. The period is where forgiveness meets you. What it cost other people may still have to be faced. Your standing with God does not wait until that cost is finished being expensive. Proverbs twenty-eight, verse thirteen. Whoever conceals their sins does not prosper, but the one who confesses and renounces them finds mercy.

Conceal is the drawer doing its job. Confess is you opening it while the hand on the lock is still yours. You can be found by a child's question. You can be found by a brother who loves you enough to be specific. You can get tired of keeping two stories straight until one of them slips. Choose, uh, the earlier door. Open it— open it while it's still your hand. The Lord Jesus was the same man with the door shut as he was in a crowded street. The Father had the whole of him. You are not asked to pretend you were always clean. You are asked to come into the light where he already is, and let him make the two versions into one man. Your wife, if you have one. Your brothers. God. They can look at you without you managing the angle. Because the thing that needed a lock has been named. And forgiven. Plain as that. Mercy meets a man at the period.

Let me land it. The inside has a shape. It can look right and still be leading somewhere dead. Competence is not righteousness.

A man can be excellent at the thing people praise and be rotting where he will not look. Open the drawer before someone else does.

What I hope— what I hope you walk out with is not a harsher opinion of yourself. I hope you've got, uh, the shape that has had your hours, and that the naming is not the end of you. There is mercy on the far side of the period. Your workbook is where this gets particular. So get the questions, uh, in your ear. Which shape is yours. Drawer. Fortress. Scoreboard. Podium. Throne. Contempt. Or recliner. One. The one with the hours. Where did it show in the days right behind you. One place. Say it out loud at the table. Who will you ask. The wife test, or the brother test. Where they see you hiding. Where you are harsh. Will you hear the whole answer without a defense, and will you thank them after. How many of you already know the person. Let me see, uh, your hands. Good. If your hand stayed down, pick before you stand up. And tell a brother about the drawer. Even if it's only the habit of hiding what you really think. Give him permission to say you are the man when he sees it. Carry this. Competence is not righteousness. Open the drawer before someone else does. The marks still stand over it. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Keep that line close. Today, use it on the shape. Tables are yours. Work that part of the workbook together. One shape. One ask. I'll be around.